LUMINOSITIES

Epsilon Eridani *0.3 Suns*

Cursa *51 Suns*

Acamar *150 Suns*

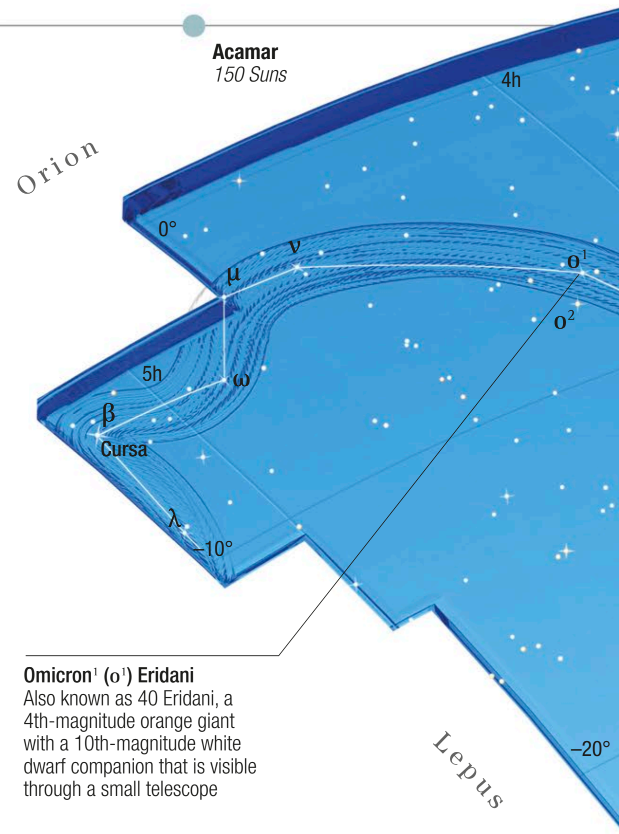
ERIDANUS THE RIVER

ERIDANUS MEANDERS FROM ORION DEEP INTO THE SOUTHERN SKY, ENDING AT THE BRIGHT STAR ACHERNAR. IN ANCIENT GREEK TIMES, THE CONSTELLATION DID NOT END SO FAR SOUTH, BUT IT WAS EXTENDED WHEN EUROPEAN NAVIGATORS BEGAN TO CHART THE SOUTHERN STARS.

Eridanus represents the mythical river that Phaethon, the son of the Sun-god Helios, fell into while attempting to drive his father's Sun-chariot across the sky.

Ancient Greek astronomers traced the celestial river as far south as the star we know as Acamar (Theta Eridani). Eridanus was later extended farther south so that it now ends at the star we call Achernar (Alpha Eridani). The names Acamar and Achernar both come from the Arabic meaning "river's end." Present-day Eridanus has the greatest north-to-south span of any constellation, nearly 60 degrees.

Eridanus contains several notable celestial objects, including the flattened, fast-spinning star, Achernar, as well as the classic barred spiral galaxy NGC 1300 (see pp.52–53), the face-on spiral NGC 1309, and the galaxy NGC 1291, which is surrounded by an outer ring in which new stars are being formed.



Omicron[1] (ο[1]) Eridani
Also known as 40 Eridani, a 4th-magnitude orange giant with a 10th-magnitude white dwarf companion that is visible through a small telescope

Achernar, the brightest star in Eridanus, is the **least spherical star** known

△ **NGC 1309**
Lying about 100 million light-years away, NGC 1309 is a spiral galaxy that is about three-quarters as wide as our own Milky Way. In this Hubble image, bright areas of active star formation can be seen in the arms, with brown dust lanes spiraling out from the pale yellow nucleus containing older stars.

◁ **NGC 1291**
A ring of newborn stars encircles the galaxy NGC 1291 in this color-enhanced image taken at infrared wavelengths by NASA's Spitzer Space Telescope. In this image, young stars are shown in red, and the older stars at the galaxy's center are shown in blue. When galaxies like this are young, star formation is concentrated near their centers, but as gas at the galaxy's center is used up, star formation moves to the outer regions, as has occurred here.

▷ **Star distances**
Eridanus's main pattern stars lie between about 10 light-years and 810 light-years from Earth. The nearest and farthest stars are both in the northern part of the constellation: Epsilon (ε) Eridani at 10.5 light-years from Earth and Lambda (λ) Eridani at about 810 light-years away.